

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 2
Painting the Stars ~ Toward Healing the Rift
13 September 2026

LVF Update 5 Septemberr
COMMUNION

Welcoming New Members

Preaching: LVF
Worship Leading: ML and JPC

Include recognition of Meg Coulter's 75-year church membership anniversary & 88th Bday

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[to center chancel]

Welcome

Words of Gathering

[Michael from the front – LVF in the back]

It is not as though
we stop and start our way through life,
jerking this way and that,
half yanking our feet from one course
and onto another.

It is not as though we go so far and then,
consulting our maps,
make a sudden turn
and head off in a new direction.

It is not as though
we choose each new beginning
from a menu of life's options.

And yet
each moment opens soft and pure

awaiting our response;
each day lifts its head from the dew-strung grasses
and offers new hope, new possibility, extra chances;
each idea stirs a constellation of thoughts into being
and we are captivated by their courses.

*May we know and celebrate new beginnings
in our lives and the lives of others
and as we do,
may we honor what has passed
and hallow its traces
through our lives, our hearts, our loves.*

*To this we commit ourselves
as those who begin anew this day.*

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Creation

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

*Hymn Of Gathering *The Sun is On the Sea and Shore*
■ The Sun is On the Sea and Shore - BROTHER JAMES' AIR.jpg

[Michael center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness

ML

Holy One,
We pause and listen to the sound of silence in this place...

We remember creation's beauty
the searing of shooting stars,
the colors of the planets in the night sky,
the space and power beyond our perceiving,
and with these memories, we are moved to prayer -
to praise the mystery of creation,
and to be grateful for the mystery of our life in this place.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

[to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

Let us pray together this Lord's Prayer, adapted by enfleshed...

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

In the center of the whirlwind
lies an eye.
Still.
Open.
Calm.
Before we come into the world,
it is as though we live in that center –
no worries,
no storms,
only peace.

As we find our way in life,
even in the midst of chaos,
may we remember that center
and, as the need arises,
and it must,
may we hold
to the calm, open, stillness,
knowing it as home.

[adptlvf/gvosper]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Welcoming New Members

[Jay to lectern]

Reading from Our Tradition

JPC & ML

from On the Origin of Species by Charles Darwin "Conclusion"

It is interesting to contemplate a tangled bank, clothed with many plants of many kinds, with birds singing on the bushes, with various insects flitting about, and with worms crawling through the damp earth, and to reflect that these elaborately constructed forms, so different from each other, and dependent upon each other in so complex a manner, have all been produced by laws acting around us.

These laws, taken in the largest sense, being
Growth with Reproduction;
Inheritance which is almost implied by reproduction;
Variability from the indirect and direct action of the conditions of life, and from use and disuse;
a Ratio of Increase so high as to lead to a Struggle for Life,
and as a consequence to Natural Selection,
entailing Divergence of Character and the
Extinction of less improved forms.

Thus, from the war of nature, from famine and death, the most exalted object which we are capable of conceiving, namely, the production of the higher animals, directly follows.

There is grandeur in this view of life, with its several powers, having been originally breathed by the Creator into a few forms or into one; and that, whilst this planet has gone cycling on according to the fixed law of gravity, from so simple a beginning endless forms most beautiful and most wonderful have been, and are being, evolved.

from the Gospel of John

ML

from John 1 [- 1:1-5, 10-13]

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God.

What is this ?? [You'd asked me to include it this day and wanted Jay to read it- ML]

from 1 Corinthians 15.58

Therefore, my siblings, remain strong. Let nothing move you from resistance. Keep giving yourselves fully to God and know you do not labor in vain. Your stories shared are not in vain. Your solidarity is not in vain. Your proclamation is not in vain. Your protests are not in vain. Your phone calls are not in vain. Your survival is not in vain. Your hope is not in vain. Your care for one another is not in vain. Those in power come and go but the Spirit of Life is eternal. She takes all our offerings shared for Love's sake and multiplies them. Look not to thrones of power

for the fruit of your labor. Is a single sister encouraged because you shared your story? Is a single brother committing to deepen his commitment to challenging toxic masculinity? Is a single nonbinary beloved encouraged by your protests in the street? The power of God, the ultimate power-with, makes a mockery of patriarchy, makes queer and transphobia bend low, makes white supremacy kiss the feet of justice, makes every spirit of destruction tremble at the sound of collective voices rising. Tend to your pain but do not let them convince you that your work is in vain. Every act of resistance in the directions of Love and Justice shall bring forth Life.

This is the witness of the ancients...

Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition ... to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

[2 minutes of silence, then CB transition out of silence]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gathered in this place:

We acknowledge

a Power, a Presence

within us

within all people,

a creative, energizing Presence,

Divine,

bonding everything that exists

through patterns of attraction and co-operation,

in endless movement

toward new possibilities,

creating an interrelational universe

that makes human life possible.

Conscious of this Divine presence

within and among us,

we open ourselves to new possibilities.

We expand our minds,

we embrace change,

we take risks,

we discard what no longer gives meaning to life,

we deepen our awareness and appreciation

of this Presence

emerging in us.

***On this day, we give thanks for the wonderful human gift
of conscious awareness.***

We give thanks, that in us,
the universe has found a way to reflect upon itself,
to sing, to dance,
to celebrate the joy of sound and movement,
to consciously love,
to be enthralled by the creation of new life
and new possibilities.

We open ourselves to the challenge
of fully co-operating with the energizing, creative,
Divine Presence in our own personal development,
in our relationships with all other people
and in our connectedness with and **care for planet Earth.**

***To all that is,
and to all that could be
through the power of the Presence
within all things,
we say, Amen. [mmoorwood]***

[Christoph transition for Choir]

Meditation Anthem

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon

Toward Healing the Rift

LVF

[Christoph transition as Michael & Jay go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings

We give thanks, Great Transformer.

You are the power that turns helium and hydrogen
into starfields,
and exploding stars into building blocks of life.
You are the intelligence that, through deep time,
turns lava into llamas,
and bacteria into Beethoven's symphonies.

At the Cana wedding,
Jesus turned water into wine,
the miracle being not the transformation
(for this is your signature),

but the time it took –
the wink of a mother's eye.

And so this morning as we gather at this table,
we know, Holy One, that in your hands,
we too may be transformed, and learn again
that you have saved the best in us for last.

We take this bread as Jesus took it,
we break it and we bless it,
knowing that this bread of new life
is one of the building blocks
of the life we share.

We take this cup as Jesus did,
we pour it and we bless it,
remembering that the miracles
of transformation begin
with this cup of hope
we share.

Prayer of Blessing

Holy One,
we come to this table,
incarnating in our blood and bones,
in chemistry and consciousness,
this shape-shifting universe.

As we receive this bread and this cup –
symbols of self-giving love,
we remember Jesus and his life, death,
and life from death, that continues
to evolve in each of our lives.
We pray this with the Spirit of Life
that flowed through Jesus
and now flows through our bodies
and into this world.
Amen and Amen.

Words of Invitation

You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith,
or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[... to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

Offertory

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your praise shall sound from shore to shore
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[.. to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

Holy Mystery,
we pray this morning ---
mindful of all that has brought us together,
of the Spirit of Life at work in our lives,
and of what may be possible
if we allow this Spirit to work
freely in each of us.

Let our generosity increase
as our lives are transformed
so that we may be
light and life in this place.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

ML

Words of Blessing

LVF

Let us share this Gaelic blessing that comes
to us from our ancestors long ago:

Deep peace of the running wave to you...

Deep peace of the flowing air to you...

Deep peace of the quiet earth to you...

Deep peace of the shining stars to you...

Deep peace of the One who is peace to you...

both this day and in all the days to come.

Amen and Amen!

[adapt/gaelicblessing]

Choral Response

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

*Hymn for the Journey

Wake Now My Senses

SLANE

In the drive with descant -

Wake now my senses, and hear the Earth call,
feel the deep power of being in all,
keep with the web of creation your vow,
giving receiving, as love shows us how.

Wake now my reason, reach out for the new,
join with each trav'ler who quests for the true,
honor the beauty and wisdom of time,
transcend our limits and touch the sublime.

Wake now my vision, the dream we hold dear,
brighten our pathway with radiance here,
journey together with all who will share,
love for the planet transformed by our care.

--lyrics Mikelson

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music